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U.S. Economics News:

- **Monetary Policy Stance:** Fed likely to maintain current rates at March 18th meeting rather than cut, given 2.4% headline inflation and 2.5% core inflation persisting above 2% target. Oil supply shock represents relative price shift not requiring Fed intervention; easing policy to cushion consumer impact would risk creating broader inflation rather than addressing temporary commodity disruption.[3]
- **GDP Growth Weakens:** Fourth quarter 2025 real GDP revised down to 0.7% annualized rate from initial 1.4%, driven by downward revisions to exports, consumption, business investment, and government spending. Core GDP (consumer spending, business investment, residential construction) grew 1.9% while government purchases shrank 5.8% annualized, largest drag since Q3 2020, contributing to slower growth paired with higher 3.8% GDP price inflation.[3]
- **Housing Market Stagnates:** January housing starts rose 7.2% to 1.487 million annual rate but gain entirely from volatile multi-unit category jumping 29.9%, while single-family starts declined 2.8% and remain 6.5% below year-ago levels. Building permits fell 5.4% with single-family permits down 11.6% year-over-year; completions outpaced starts for tenth time in twelve months as builders focus on finishing projects amid elevated home prices and affordability challenges.[3]
- **Strategic Petroleum Reserve:** US Strategic Petroleum Reserve held 415.4 million barrels as of March 6th, up 19.8% from July 2023 low but still 34.9% below 638.1 million when Biden took office. Reserve equates to 125 days of crude net imports with maximum 4.4 million barrel daily drawdown capacity taking 13 days to reach market after authorization; not long-term solution though could temporarily ease price pressures.[3]
- **Strait of Hormuz Disruption:** Approximately 14 million of 77 million daily global crude barrels transit Strait of Hormuz, with 89% destined for Asian markets led by China (37.7%), India (14.7%), South Korea (12%), Japan (10.9%). US reduced reliance significantly with Strait flows representing only 2.5% of total volume and 6% of US crude imports in Q1 2025, limiting direct domestic supply impact compared to Asian economies.[3]
- **Energy Sector Dominance:** All five S&P 500 Energy subsectors ranked among top 15 performers year-to-date through March 6th, with sector returning 26.47% led by Commodity Chemicals (49.14%), Oil & Gas Refining (35%), and Construction & Engineering (28%). Energy benefited from Iran war supply disruptions, winter storms, and investor diversification demand; WTI crude spiked 35.63% in week following February 27th war inception, supporting sector outperformance amid broader market weakness.[3]

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Digital Assets News:

- **First Positive Month:** March 2025 represents a potential turning point for cryptocurrency exchange-traded funds, marking the first month of net positive inflows since October 2024. This reversal follows five consecutive months of investor withdrawals and signals renewed institutional confidence in digital asset exposure through regulated investment vehicles, potentially driven by improving market sentiment and clearer regulatory frameworks.[5]
- **Iran War Impact:** Bitcoin demonstrated its characteristic volatility during geopolitical tensions, initially dropping 8.5% as conflict with Iran commenced due to risk-off sentiment among investors. However, the cryptocurrency has since staged a notable recovery, climbing 11% from its recent lows as markets digested the situation and some investors sought alternative stores of value amid traditional market uncertainty.[5]
- **Market Structure Bill:** The Senate is not anticipated to advance the legislation before the April timeframe, likely due to competing legislative priorities and the need to build broader bipartisan consensus. Key stakeholders continue negotiations over provisions addressing market concentration and competitive practices, with committee hearings and amendments still pending before any floor vote can be scheduled.[5]
- **103 Countries Have Established Formal Cryptocurrency Regulatory Frameworks:** As of 2024, over 103 nations worldwide have implemented comprehensive legal and regulatory structures governing digital assets, ranging from licensing requirements for exchanges and custodians to consumer protection measures, anti-money laundering protocols, and taxation guidelines. This represents a significant shift from the regulatory uncertainty that characterized the crypto industry's early years, demonstrating growing institutional acceptance.[5]
- **SAB 122:** The SEC issued Staff Accounting Bulletin 122 in July 2024, superseding the controversial SAB 121 from 2022. This new guidance relaxed the stringent balance sheet liability requirements that had effectively prevented traditional banks from offering crypto custody services, allowing financial institutions greater flexibility in safeguarding digital assets while maintaining appropriate accounting disclosures and risk management frameworks.[5]

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Geopolitics News:

- **China:** Exports surged 22% in early 2026 driven by automation and AI, but Guangdong workers face disappearing jobs and falling wages as factories increasingly require no human workers.[1]
- **Iran:** Betting on endurance strategy to outlast US and Israel by disrupting energy routes and jolting markets; IRGC firmly in control directing battlefield operations and contingencies.[1]
- **Iran:** Launched drones and missiles across Gulf hitting Dubai airport and UAE oil facility; warned world should prepare for $200 oil and declared US-bound tankers legitimate targets.[1]
- **Iran:** New Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei wounded and likely disfigured according to Pentagon, only releasing written statements without voice or video since Israeli strike killed his father.[1]
- **Iran:** Offers Hormuz passage to countries expelling US and Israeli diplomats; Foreign Minister denies seeking ceasefire or exchanging messages with Washington despite ongoing negotiations speculation.[1]
- **Israel:** Netanyahu threatens new Supreme Leader and vows continued strikes on Hezbollah while acknowledging bombardment may not collapse clerical government despite degrading Revolutionary Guards.[1]
- **Russia:** Trump and Putin discussed Iran war and Ukraine peace prospects; Trump temporarily lifted sanctions on Russian oil at sea until April 11 to add hundreds of millions of barrels.[1]
- **Switzerland:** Sticking to existing mandate for trade negotiations with US to finalize tariff deal after being included in Trump's excess industrial capacity and forced labor investigations.[1]
- **Ukraine:** Wants money and technology in return for helping Middle Eastern nations defend against Iranian drones; sent specialist teams to Qatar, UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Jordan.[1]
- **United States:** Trump threatens Iran with strikes "twenty times harder" if oil flow disrupted; called for coalition to reopen Hormuz as allies voice caution about military action.[1]

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The Good News:

- **Nuclear Breakthrough:** TerraPower received the first construction permit this century for a commercial fourth-generation reactor, converting a Wyoming coal plant using liquid sodium coolant instead of water. New DOE rules have dramatically reduced environmental and security requirements for experimental reactors, with President Trump's executive order targeting three operational units by July 4th to accelerate next-generation nuclear development.[2]
- **AI Drug Discovery:** Machine learning is identifying treatments for previously incurable diseases in hours versus years. MIT researchers found new compounds against antibiotic-resistant MRSA and gonorrhoea, while Cambridge scientists discovered five novel Parkinson's candidates targeting Lewy body protein clumps. Harvard's AI model identified 8,000 approved drugs potentially repurposable for 17,000 different diseases, dramatically expanding treatment options.[2]
- **Electric Aviation:** The FAA launched pilot projects across 26 states testing electric aircraft and eVTOLs — large electric drones carrying passengers or cargo. Eight approved projects include Manhattan air taxis, Texas regional flights, and Florida medical response, giving startups like Joby and Archer real-world testing before final certification, accelerating the transition to emissions-free flight.[2]
- **Ultra-Fast EV Charging:** BYD's Blade Battery 2.0 achieves 10-70% charge in five minutes and 20-97% in twelve minutes using 1.5-megawatt chargers, matching gas station refueling speeds. The battery maintains performance in -30°C conditions and delivers over 621-mile range, eliminating the primary practical barrier to mass electric vehicle adoption.[2]

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Dividend Portfolio News:

- **CAT:** Caterpillar added to Liberty All-Star Growth Fund's portfolio in February. Separately, Atlas Energy signed a framework agreement with CAT for power generation assets through 2029, expanding its energy infrastructure presence.[4]
- **CL:** Colgate-Palmolive raised its quarterly dividend by 1.9% to $0.53 per share and ranked first in growth factor grades among S&P consumer staples holdings, demonstrating sustained pricing power and financial momentum.[4]
- **GPC:** Genuine Parts outlined its breakup plan and AI initiatives at the UBS conference, with shares rallying on investor optimism about strategic restructuring and technology integration efforts.[4]
- **LMT:** Pentagon report indicates F-35 software upgrades have stalled, raising concerns about program delays. Separately, Lockheed's Sikorsky division introduced an autonomous cargo helicopter with Robinson, advancing unmanned aviation capabilities.[4]
- **LRCX:** Lam Research may be interested in acquiring BE Semiconductor according to reports. IBM and Lam announced collaboration to advance sub-1 nanometer logic scaling. Fund managers increased ownership positions in the stock.[4]
- **QCOM:** Qualcomm downgraded by Seaport citing shrinking market share and memory supply constraints. BofA reinstated coverage with cautious outlook, seeing "lukewarm" growth ahead. Separately, Qualcomm partnered with Wayve to expand automated driving systems.[4]
- **SYK:** Stryker allegedly hit by Iran-linked cyberattack per WSJ report, with shares extending losses amid ongoing operational impact from the cybersecurity incident.[4]
- **TEL:** TE Connectivity raised its quarterly dividend by 9.9% to $0.78 per share, marking a significant increase in shareholder returns.[4]

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Growth Portfolio News

- **AMD:** Partnered with Celestica to bring Helios rack-scale AI platform to market. BNP notes AMD likely has more gigawatt deals in pipeline with accelerating CPU demand. CEO Lisa Su reportedly meeting Samsung chief in South Korea. Microsoft to send next-gen Xbox prototypes to game developers in 2027.[4]
- **CVX:** U.S. oil CEOs warned Trump administration energy turmoil could worsen. Iran war could deliver $60B windfall for U.S. producers with crude above $100. Chevron and Shell nearing first major Venezuela production deals since Maduro's capture.[4]
- **FTNT:** Fortinet likely to see AI monetization boost according to analysts. SentinelOne's mixed results and Netskope's softer Q4 impacted competitive landscape.[4]
- **HOOD:** Robinhood's February equity and options trading volume declined month-over-month, while crypto volume increased. Retail investors pulling back from equities despite seasonal patterns per JPMorgan.[4]
- **MARA:** Crypto stocks rose on Bitcoin rally near $74,000. MARA topped gainers in financials wrap. Gains continued as Bitcoin sell-offs reportedly entering final phase.[4]
- **NVDA:** GTC 2026 keynote expected to provide bullish catalyst with potential $4T outlook according to Wedbush. Launched Nemotron 3 Super AI model. Partnered with Palantir on sovereign AI architecture. Investing $2B in Nebius collaboration and backing Thinking Machines startup.[4]
- **TSM:** TSMC January-February revenue rose 30% amid strong global AI demand. China's second-largest chipmaker preparing 7nm chipmaking technology. Apple's MacBook Neo facing higher costs from increased memory and CPU expenses.[4]

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Phone: (985)727-0770 Website: IntentionalOwnership.com Address: 510 N. Jefferson Covington, La 70433

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Summary:

In regard to the United States Economy, fourth quarter GDP growth was revised sharply lower to just 0.7% annualized, driven by declining exports, consumption, and business investment. Oil prices surged nearly 50% following the Iran conflict, though the US shows greater resilience as a net petroleum exporter. The Fed appears positioned to hold rates steady given inflation persisting above target. January's trade deficit narrowed significantly as exports climbed and imports fell, with China dropping to fourth among exporters.

In the world of digital assets, March marked the first month of positive inflows to cryptocurrency funds since October following five consecutive months of withdrawals. Bitcoin initially dropped over 8% as Iran tensions escalated but has since recovered 11% from recent lows. Over 103 countries have now established formal regulatory frameworks governing digital assets. The SEC's Staff Accounting Bulletin 122 relaxed custody requirements for traditional banks, allowing greater participation in crypto safekeeping services.

Recently around the globe, Iran launched attacks on Dubai and UAE facilities while threatening $200 oil and declaring US-bound tankers legitimate targets. The new Supreme Leader remains wounded and absent from public view following Israeli strikes. Trump temporarily lifted Russian oil sanctions while discussing Ukraine peace prospects with Putin. Ukraine is offering drone defense expertise to Middle Eastern nations in exchange for funding and technology. China's exports surged on automation advances.

For the good news, TerraPower received America's first construction permit this century for a fourth-generation nuclear reactor using liquid sodium coolant technology. Artificial intelligence is revolutionizing drug discovery, identifying treatments for antibiotic-resistant infections and Parkinson's disease in hours rather than years. The FAA launched pilot projects testing electric aircraft and passenger drones for urban air mobility. BYD's latest battery technology achieves gas-station refueling speeds with five-minute charging times.

In the news for the dividend portfolio, Colgate-Palmolive increased its dividend 1.9% and ranked first in growth metrics among consumer staples. TE Connectivity raised its payout nearly 10% per share. Genuine Parts outlined breakup plans that rallied shares. Lam Research faces acquisition speculation while collaborating with IBM on advanced chip manufacturing. Qualcomm received downgrades citing market share losses despite partnerships expanding automated driving systems.

And, for the growth portfolio, AMD partnered with Celestica on AI platforms while analysts note accelerating demand. Chevron could see $60 billion in windfall profits with oil above $100 as Venezuela production deals near completion. Nvidia's upcoming conference is expected to provide bullish catalysts with partnerships across sovereign AI architecture. TSMC reported 30% revenue growth driven by global AI semiconductor demand. Robinhood saw equity volumes decline while crypto activity increased.

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